family have flown over, friends too. If I take four wickets, I will become the all-time highest wicket taker for England, going beyond Ian Botham.

We're in Antigua where the pitch is docile, and taking wickets is as difficult as anywhere in the world. The pitch will not help. The ball will not move. Prising out West Indian batters takes long periods of concentration, subtle plans that take place only with sustained pressure. I have taken two wickets in the first innings and then one more in the second, the important one of Marlon Samuels. Captain Denesh Ramdin is unbeaten on 57. Time is running out to win the Test match somehow.

As I continue to run in to bowl, Stuart Broad comes to speak to me at mid-on. 'How about trying to bowl a leg cutter?' he suggests. I haven't bowled many, and it's not something that has been a huge part of the 384 previous wickets for England. The majority of those have been the subtleties of feel between my index and middle finger, that callus, building up rugged dead skin over years, dictating whether the balls move in or away or go straight on. I run in and try one. It's quite floaty, easy to read, and comes out of my hand slowly without moving. I huff at Broady on the way back to my mark and shrug when I reach him. 'Bowl it again,' he says, 'but try it as fast as you can.'

It comes out perfectly, revolutions fizzing in the air so rapidly that you can hear the sound. Ramdin edges the ball and then I see Alastair Cook diving to his left, taking the catch at full stretch. I haven't realised quite how much this landmark must mean to me – but it suddenly hits me, all the distance travelled, all the miraculous coincidences, the daily act of just showing up again and again. Cook and Broad are involved too, like it was meant to be. Ball in hand, I turn to show it to the crowd, who are on their feet, and spot Daniella and the girls, my mum and dad, and then, to their right, Ian Botham, both arms up, applauding too.